NURU KARIM:
Where Architecture Learns To Listen

From the bamboo-orchid terminal at Guwahati airport to projects across continents, the Mumbai-based architect explores how infrastructure can carry memory, identity, care and cultural meaning across diverse landscapes



Picture Credit: Sanket Bhalerao

Nuru Karim

The moment you step into the newly inaugurated terminal at Guwahati's Lokapriya Gopinath Bardoloi International Airport (LGBIA), it becomes clear this is not an airport designed merely for movement. Light filters through a sweeping bamboo canopy, the scale feels generous without being overwhelming and the space carries a quiet confidence rooted in the verdant landscape of Assam. It does not announce arrival with spectacle. Instead, it invites you in with warmth and familiarity.

This first impression is deliberate. It reflects how Nuru Karim believes infrastructure should behave, not as a machine that processes people, but as a civic space that remembers where it stands.

For the Mumbai-based architect, architecture has never been about isolated objects or singular gestures. It has always been about systems and relationships that unfold between people, climate, material and time. At LGBIA, developed as part of a new generation of terminals under Adani Airport Holdings Limited (AAHL), these ideas come together with unusual clarity. The terminal meets global benchmarks of efficiency and performance, yet it does so without erasing local identity, demonstrating that large-scale infrastructure can still carry emotion, memory and a sense of belonging.

Karim's way of thinking about space was shaped long before he formally encountered architecture. His earliest influences came from observing nature and reading widely, particularly about social insect engineering. He was fascinated by how ants and termites create complex, adaptive environments collectively, without drawings, hierarchy or a central authority. These structures respond intelligently to climate, movement and resources, evolving over time rather than being imposed all at once. As he travelled across regions and cultures, Karim noticed similar patterns in human settlements, where spaces grow through use, adaptation and shared behaviour. Architecture, he realised, was not a static form but a living system shaped continuously by place and people.

His academic journey through Mumbai, Montreal and London